

Why does Beth's husband tolerate this situation? Because he has been conditioned to do so. He and Beth have a high-consumption lifestyle congruent with that of his in-law's. Yet their ability to sustain such a lifestyle is a function of their being controlled. Robert and Ruth have communicated a central message to Beth, not so much in words as in deeds:

*Beth, you and your husband are not capable of generating enough income on your own to maintain your ascribed station in life. You are economically handicapped. You and your husband need our special brand of economic outpatient care.*

Are Robert and Ruth correct that Beth and her husband would be unable to achieve in life without assistance? An objective third party would contend that they are. But what would the same objective third party say if he had examined this situation from its origin? He might have concluded that Robert and Ruth made a special effort to prove their hypothesis. After even just a few years of receiving aggressive and overbearing economic outpatient care, Beth and her husband have lost much of their ambition, economic self-confidence, and independence. No one will ever know if this couple could have functioned productively on its own. Beth and her husband were never given this opportunity.

The role of enlightened parents is to strengthen the weak. Robert and Ruth did just the opposite. They weakened the weak and continue to do so today. Not surprisingly, they never appreciated their role in causing much of the dependency Beth and her husband experience today. Today Ann has some resentment, even bitterness, toward her parents. She holds them responsible for creating the economic and emotional dependency that her sister and brother-in-law must deal with every day. Ann has learned much from Beth and her husband's experiences.

Ann is especially sensitive about her parents' role in usurping control of her sister's children. In them, the mistakes of the past are likely to be repeated. Ann can only wish that her parents had followed some simple rules about raising children to be independent. They can't now. But Ann can. It's not too late for her. Ann will never allow her parents to control any portion of her life or the lives of her husband and children.